

VANDANA LUTHRA

49, BEAUTY AND FITNESS EXPERT
FOUNDER AND MENTOR, VLCC
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1989 Rs 50,000
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 400 crore

HEMANT CHAWLA

SITTING PRETTY

As a child, Vandana Luthra had a fetish for cutting everyone's hair and experimenting with facials on her mother. Her father had, however, set his mind on sending her abroad to do an MBA. Creating a wellness chain and making Vandana Luthra's Curls and Curves (VLCC) brand a household name was not exactly an ideal profession. But the passion for personal grooming was too strong. A little less than two decades on, India's largest slimming and fitness corporate, spread across 150 centres in 70 cities across India and overseas, continues to redefine health, wealth and beauty.

"When I started off, obesity was an epidemic. Today, it is more of a social problem," says Luthra. The search for a new, unique and comprehensive recipe for health—skin, hair and weight—took the Delhi University graduate to Germany, London and Paris to study nutrition, cosmetology, and a little bit of hair treatment. Pre-reform India held little promise for Luthra. But even an early marriage at 21 and two quick daughters could not dampen the urge to create a brand which would offer "fitness and beauty" as a holistic solution. "I opened my first VLCC centre in Delhi in 1989. My husband was sure that I would close it in six months," she remembers. VLCC has now forayed into international markets by opening five centres in the UAE.

But setting new parameters through a fusion of ayurveda and modern scientific solutions was easier said than done with the medical fraternity questioning her claim to deliver scientific weight loss and personalised packages. "It took me seven years to convince doctors and today 70 per cent of my customers come from them," says Luthra. The invariably glossed and rouged Luthra has now turned to training as well. The VLCC Institute of Beauty Health and Management, one of the first vocational training academies of its kind, offers courses in beauty and nutrition. It's a long and curving road ahead, but Luthra is all set for it, lean and preened.

by Nivedita Mukherjee

biggest OBSTACLE

Opposition from medical fraternity, which was not convinced about her solutions

turning POINT

When she opened the first VLCC centre which gave her the required confidence

SUCCESS MANTRA

She believes that wellness has roots in both fitness as well as beauty

